Till the '70s, slums were considered illegal, and many were demolished. In 1971, the Maharashtra Slum Areas (Improvement Clearance and Redevelopment) Act was passed, and basic amenities like sanitation and water were provided. In the '90s, a committee under senior IAS officer Dinesh Afzalpurkar recommended the use of land as a resource to tackle the problem of burgeoning slums. The government accepted it in 1995 and the SRA was created. Under its schemes, builders can redevelop slums into tenement buildings to house slum-dwellers. In return, they can develop part of the land for sale in the market. Over the years, the size of rehabilitation tenements grew from 180 sq. ft to 225 sq. ft, 269 sq. ft and now, 300 sq. ft; the cut-off date for legalised slums has been pushed back from 1995 to 2000. Some 253,421 tenements constructed under SRA projects have been given occupation certificates by July end. However, officials say that the goal of a slum-free Mumbai, with residents being housed in highrises, is a long way off.

A senior SRA official says that around 380 slum rehabilitation schemes have been stuck for years due to lack of clearance from the Union defence and environment, forests and climate change ministries, the Civil Aviation Authority and due to legal/financial issues. Work on 517 schemes approved since 2008-09 is yet to begin. To kickstart stalled projects, the SRA has empaneled around 30 developers, who will bid for tenders floated by the authority. In another option, financial institutions that have invested in stalled SRA projects will be empaneled and can appoint a new developer to complete work. So far, of the 380 pending projects, 161 have been revived. "We are working to give an impetus to stalled projects and ensure they are implemented efficiently," says Satish Lokhande, chief executive officer, SRA.

SLUM-CENTRIC POLICIES

Recent steps by the Maharashtra government for the benefit of slum-dwellers in SRA project areas

- Those staying in shanties constructed between 2000 and 2011 to get flats at Rs 2.5 lakh
- Plans to let government agencies like MHADA to undertake work on stalled SRA projects
- Mandatory for developers to pay two years' advance rent to slum-dwellers for transit accommodation, post-dated cheques for another year
- State cabinet to reduce lock-in period for sale of SRA rehabilitation tenements from 10 to seven years
- In-principle nod for allowing residents on first floor of chawls to be covered under SRA schemes

In around 150 SRA schemes, developers have defaulted on paying around Rs 602 crore as rent to slum-dwellers who are in transit accommodation while their houses are being redeveloped. In August, the SRA issued a circular mandating that developers must pay two years' rent in advance and submit post-dated cheques for another year.

"Several SRA projects have been languishing for 10-15 years," says Krishna Hegde, deputy leader and spokesperson of the Shinde-led Sena. "Residents evicted are yet to get houses and are living in dilapidated transit accommodation...the government is looking into the matter."

'PRO-BUILDER SCHEME'

Critics point to how the SRA scheme, instead of catalysing urban renewal, is heavily tilted in favour of private builders. "It is a pro-builder scheme," alleges Ramesh Prabhu, chairman, Maharashtra Societies Welfare Association. "Builders are also responsible for creating slums...builders, developers, politicians, babus have become richer in the name of the poor." He points to how successive governments increased the size of SRA tenements and hiked cut-off years for legalising slums, which served to encourage people to create new slums and nurture vote banks.

Sitaram Shelar, co-convenor, Hamara Shaher Mumbai Abhiyan, agrees. "The land belongs to the government, which bears the cost, but it is the builder who benefits. The utilisation of land is more towards the resale component, at around 60-65 per cent, with residents housed in the rest. This ensures that SRA tenements are a vertical version of slums with no gardens, open spaces or facilities that slum-dwellers can access," he explains.

Shelar complains about the faulty attitude of policymakers towards slums. "Slums are not a problem," he says, "but a source of energy for the city. They provide labour to it." As a remedy, Shelar proposes that the size of flats for slum-dwellers be hiked to 350 sq. ft, and an increase in the share of housing be given to government agencies such as the Mumbai Metropolitan Regional Development Authority (MMRDA) to put up those uprooted by Mumbai's infrastructure projects. Former minister Varsha Gaikwad of the Congress says that SRA schemes must be pro-people, not pro-builder. "Decisions should not be taken from the comfort of air-conditioned cabins but must take ground realities into account," she stresses.

Varun Singh, founder, Square Feet India, a real estate news website, says that the government must ensure that slum-dwellers do not get multiple houses. "Now, an individual may take multiple benefits under SRA projects...some sell off their rehabilitation tenements and move elsewhere. These leakages must be plugged, but no government wants to bite the bullet as the slum-dwellers are a powerful vote bank," he says. ■